

BASIC PLANTING TECHNIQUES

Once you have planned your garden, and assessed the aspect and soil, you can begin planting. Giving new plants a good start by improving soil will result in strong, healthy specimens that put on a display

year after year. Choose a fine day when the soil is not frozen or waterlogged and, before starting, make sure the soil is free of weeds. Water all plants well in preparation and water them again after planting.

Choosing healthy plants

Before going to the garden center or nursery, make a list of your chosen plants, and try to stick to it, to avoid making impulsive purchases. If some of the plants are not available, remember to check the eventual size and required growing conditions of any substitutes to make sure that they will fulfill your needs.

Check each plant to ensure you have chosen the healthiest specimen. Look at the leaves and stems for signs of pests and diseases, and reject any plant with wilted foliage. Then turn over the pot and check to see if there is a mass of roots growing through the drainage holes, a sign that the plant is “root bound” and has been growing in the pot for too long. Finally, select plants with lots of leafy stems and plump buds.

Preparing the ground

It is always wise to take a few hours to prepare the soil well before you plant. Clear the site of any large stones and remove all weeds, ensuring that you dig out the whole root system of perennial weeds, like dandelions. Start by hand-weeding the site.



Remove the weeds

When weeding, try to remove the root systems completely to prevent the weeds from growing back. Pernicious weeds, such as ground elder and bindweed, may need to be treated with a weed killer.

You can apply a weed killer, if necessary, to tackle pernicious weeds such as bindweed, ground elder, Japanese knotweed, horsetail, nettles, and brambles. If weeds are really problematic, consider covering the site with some old carpet or plastic sheeting for a few seasons. This forms a physical barrier against settling weed seeds, and the lack of light and moisture prevents weed growth. When the site has been



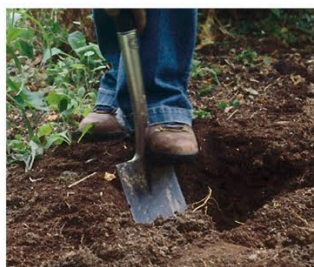
Feed the soil

When making a new bed or border, enrich the soil by digging in well-rotted organic matter, such as manure or garden compost, before planting. Apply organic matter as a mulch around plants on existing beds.

cleared, enrich the soil with organic matter, such as well-rotted manure or garden compost. On a large plot, dig a series of trenches to the depth of a spade across the area and add manure to the base of each trench. Alternatively, spread an 3in (8cm) layer of organic matter over the border, and dig it into the top 6in (15cm) of soil. Dig in some horticultural grit to heavy clays to improve drainage. Finally, rake the surface.

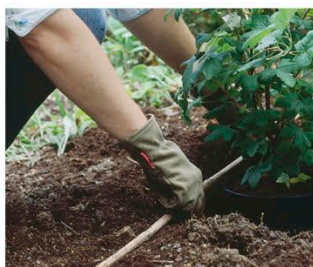
PLANTING A PERENNIAL OR SHRUB

Shrubs form the backbone of a garden, providing permanent structure, while most perennials die down in winter and emerge again in spring. Plants grown in containers can be planted at any time of year, but avoid times when the ground is frozen or excessively wet or dry. Also, prepare the soil well before you start (see above), so your plants establish quickly and produce healthy growth.



1 Make a planting hole

First, water the plants well. Dig out a planting hole for each plant, making sure that it is twice the diameter of the container and a little deeper. Fork the bottom and sides of the hole, and add some controlled-release fertilizer to the excavated soil.



2 Check planting depth

Remove the plant from its pot, teasing out the roots if they are congested. Use a cane to check that the plant will be at the same depth as it was in its pot. Put the plant in the hole and steadily trickle in water as you backfill with soil, firming as you go.



3 Water and mulch

Water the plant. Spread a mulch of organic matter around the plant, avoiding the stems, to conserve moisture and suppress weeds. Water plants in dry spells until fully established. Each spring, rake in a general-purpose fertilizer around the plant.

PLANTING DEPTHS

Most plants need to be planted at the same depth as they were in their pots or, if they are bare-root trees or shrubs, plant them at the depth they were growing at in the field, indicated by a dark soil mark on the stems. Among the exceptions are bearded irises (below); their rhizomes will rot if buried so they should be planted with them exposed. Sun-loving shrubs and perennials, such as verbascums and sedums, also thrive when planted slightly above the soil. Moisture-loving plants like hostas prefer to be buried a little deeper than ground level.

